

philosophies of the time, including Hermeticism, natural magic, and proto-sciences such as alchemy, which had its golden age during the Renaissance and which gave birth to modern chemistry.

Natural magic, based on various theoretical and experimental explorations into the nature of the cosmos, contrasted with ceremonial magic, which was about practice and steeped in mysterious ritual and symbols. Ritualistic Rosicrucianism and a Western Christian form of Kabbalah flourished at this time. The museum-laboratory of the German Kabbalist thinker Athanasius Kircher, sited in Rome, attracted

visitors from across Europe to wonder at his seemingly magical demonstrations of magnetism and to gaze at specimens of supposed mermaids.

Both the Protestant Reformation and its Catholic response, the Counter-Reformation, took place in the Renaissance. The Christian Church was politically and socially powerful, many monarchs believed that they were God's appointees, and roles such as that of the Holy Roman Emperor bestowed vast power. So it was that many people of status, Protestant and Catholic alike, dreaded threats to their positions and consulted those steeped in the occult to allay their fears.

“The highest mountain, the oldest books, the strangest people, there you will find the [Philosopher’s] Stone.”

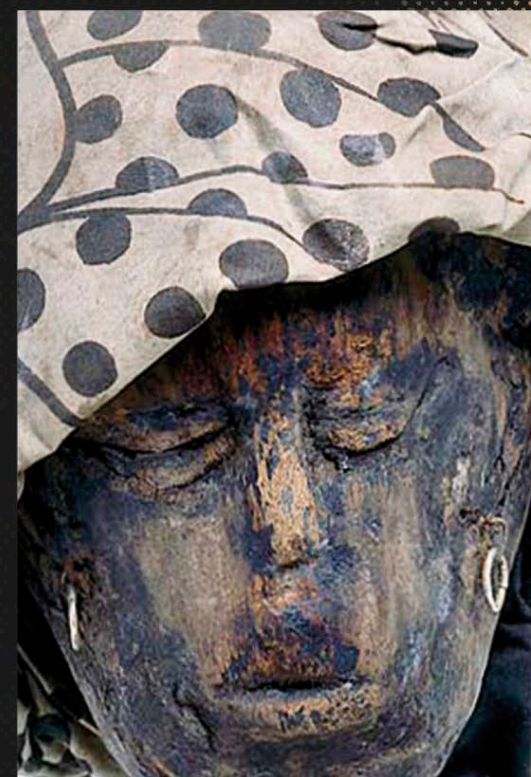
ATHANASIUS KIRCHER AND JOHANN STEPHAN KESTLER, *PHYSIOLOGIA KIRCHERIANA EXPERIMENTALIS*, 1680



Mysteries of alchemy see p.150



Condemned witches see p.180



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